

Bright spots: Pacer Kranti Goud (below) and left-arm spinner Shree Charani (facing page) were two big positives from India's tour of England.

Its bowlers hunted in packs as they restricted a determined India to 275 for nine. Once more, when batters took on the attack and struck at a fast pace, India, quite quickly, ran out of ideas.

The sixth loss came in a rain-curtailed, 29-overs-a-side game at Lord's against an England lineup sans Heather Knight. India's bowlers — who had dominated the English side through most of the five-match T20Is and in the first ODI — could only watch as the top order made quick work of a 144-run target. This came after Sophie Ecclestone rediscovered her mojo and galvanised England's spin clique.

Here too, India eventually won the series, and quite decisively. But the slips and stumbles along the way are not easy to dismiss.

Last-minute tweaks

A major issue for India was inconsistency at the top. The Shafali-Smriti combo was lethal when it clicked, but those days weren't nearly as frequent as India would have liked. This pair has given India 893 runs at an underwhelming average of 37.20 in 25 innings. Meanwhile, Pratika and Smriti have opened the innings just 14 times (all in 2025) and have scored 1086 runs at double the average — 77.57.

With Shafali, Smriti managed only two 100-plus stands, while with Pratika she produced four, including a massive 233-run partnership that

helped India beat Ireland by 304 runs to seal its biggest win in the format.

That doesn't mean Shafali's tryst with the opening slot is a thing of the past. Her briskness, aggressive strokeplay, and blatant disregard for reputation are inimitable. Pratika is a classical player, striking at 87.43. Shafali's numbers aren't any better, but she has an extra gear that we've yet to see from Pratika.

Head coach Amol Muzumdar has virtually thrown the gauntlet by stating that Shafali will "definitely be in the mix" for India. Will the side choose proven stability over the possibility of flair?

One way to honour both may be to use Pratika at No.3, which loosens the mud under Harleen's feet. But that combination hasn't been tried out so far, and only one series — at home against Australia — remains before the World Cup to even consider experimenting.

Since South Africa toured India in 2024, Smriti's ODI trajectory has also shifted. In the 23 ODIs since, she has six hundreds and five fifties to her name. More significantly, she has frequently maintained a strike rate above 100 — not typical of her style in the format. Her command early in the innings has helped India set up some of the big scores it has posted in this period.

Skipper Harmanpreet's fluctuating fortunes with the bat have been inconvenient in the past and continue to be so today, especially when those around her have been arm-twisted to tweak their game.

The No.4 slot comes with crucial anchoring duties at a fairly brisk pace. The average run rate in women's ODIs has also, for the first time in history, crossed five runs per over this



Comparison of No.4 batters

Batter	Matches played	Runs scored	Average	Strike Rate	100/50
Harmanpreet Kaur (IND)	81	2611	42.80	77.54	6/11
Beth Mooney (AUS)	28	739	43.47	82.29	0/7
Nat Sciver-Brunt (ENG)	64	2773	55.46	99.74	8/15
Sune Luus (SA)	40	1204	43.47	82.29	0/7